



CLUE & CANDLE GAMES PRESENTS



HOST GUIDE

The Secret Santa Murder

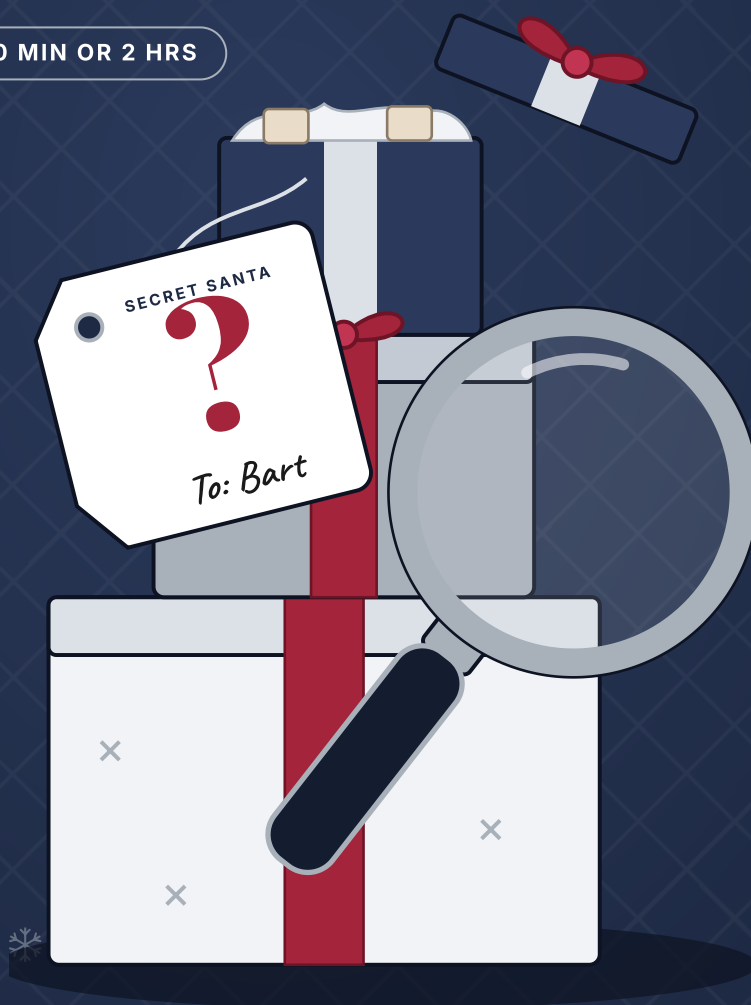
An Office Christmas Party Murder Mystery Game

8-40 PLAYERS

TEAM PLAY

60 MIN OR 2 HRS

PRINTABLE PDF



CLUE & CANDLE GAMES

US LETTER + A4 · 23 PDFs

Welcome, Detective

Thank you for hosting! This guide walks you through everything, even if you have never run a murder mystery. **You play Detective Sam Holloway**, who happened to be in the building: you read the scripts, release the evidence and keep time. You never need to act, and you are never a suspect.

❄ The story in one minute

Evergreen & Pine Co., a family-run gift-basket company, is holding its holiday party and Secret Santa exchange on December 19, from 3 to 7 pm in its converted warehouse. At 4:15 pm Bart Pringle, VP of Sales, founder’s nephew and this year’s Secret Santa organizer, opened a gift: a tin of peppermint fudge. About twenty minutes later Bart collapsed, and the paramedics could not revive him. Something harmful had been mixed into the fudge. Ten colleagues and guests each had a reason to want Bart out of the way.

❄ Three ways to play

ROLE	WHO	WHAT THEY GET
Detective Sam Holloway	The host	01 Host Guide, Scripts, evidence cards, 99 Solution (sealed)
Suspects	8–10 players	Their own 4-page booklet: a secret, three rounds of things to reveal and ask
Detective teams	Everyone else (up to 30)	A guest card (one clue, one question, one mission), a team table and a Team Case File

GOLDEN RULES

- Nobody has to perform. Reading prompts aloud is plenty.
- Suspects follow their booklets and open each Round only when you call it.
- Anyone may ask anyone anything. Evidence stays on the evidence table.
- Keep 99 sealed until Script 5.

Preparation Checklist

TICK AS YOU GO

❄ 2 weeks before

- ☐ Pick a date, a room and a format: Full Party (2–2.5 hrs) or Lunch-Hour Express (60–75 min).
- ☐ Send **02 Manager-Approval One-Pager** to whoever signs off.
- ☐ Estimate your head count and find your row in the casting table (next page).

❄ 1 week before

- ☐ **Send invitations** (file 03): suspects get their role invitation; everyone else gets the guest invitation or the email / Slack text.
- ☐ Assign the suspect roles (all 6 core roles first) and ask each suspect to bring their suggested accessory.
- ☐ Give each suspect only their own booklet (10–19), printed in an envelope or as a PDF.
- ☐ Ask 2–3 colleagues to be helpers (see Large-Room Tips).

❄ 2–3 days before

- ☐ Print using the list in 00 Start Here. Print 99 last, without reading it.
- ☐ Cut out guest cards, evidence cards, name tags and ballots.
- ☐ Fold the Team table signs; put Round 2 (E5–E8) and Round 3 (E9–E12) evidence into labeled envelopes.
- ☐ Lunch-Hour Express only: email suspects their booklets now and ask them to read pages 1–2.

❄ On the day

- ☐ Set one table per team with its sign, one Team Case File and pens.
- ☐ Set the evidence table with its sign and Round 1 cards (E1–E4) face down.
- ☐ Lay out name tags and guest cards (in order, G1 first) at the door.
- ☐ Check the microphone, the snacks and this guide's timeline.

Casting Table

8 TO 40 PLAYERS

PLAYERS	SUSPECTS	GUEST CARDS	DETECTIVE TEAMS
8	8: core 6 + Skyler, Drew	none	none: solo play, individual ballots
9	9: + Reese	none	none: solo play
10	10: all	none	none: solo play
12	10	2 (G1-G2)	3 teams of 4
16	10	6 (G1-G6)	4 teams of 4
20	10	10 (G1-G10)	4 teams of 5
25	10	15 (G1-G15)	5 teams of 5
30	10	20 (G1-G20)	5 teams of 6
35	10	20 + 5 guests without a card	5 teams of 7
40	10	20 + 10 guests without a card	6 teams of 6-7

In-between numbers: use the row below your count, deal guest cards in order from G1, and spread people evenly so every team has 4-8 members.

❄ Who plays whom

- The host plays Detective Sam Holloway. Assign the suspect roles freely.
- The six **core** suspects (booklets 10-15) are always cast, so give core roles to people who have confirmed they will come.
- Add optional suspects in this order: Skyler Moss (16), Drew Calder (17), Reese Whitfield (18), Finley Dale (19).
- Every role works for any gender. Booklets use names, never he/she.
- Good suspects enjoy chatting; nobody needs acting experience.

Fewer Players? No Problem

DROP TABLE

❄ Dropping optional suspects

The clue trail never depends on an optional suspect. If one isn't cast, their information is already covered:

OPTIONAL SUSPECT	WHAT THEY ADD	IF NOT CAST, COVERED BY
16 Skyler Moss	Took the 3:42 pm toast photo; knows who drew Bart; sign-up sheet mystery	E5 (photo credit) and E3 (tag initials). Say "the intern, Skyler, took the photo."
17 Drew Calder	No fudge on the menu; kitchen alibi; unpaid invoice	E4 (menu) and G6. If G6 isn't dealt, read it in Round 1.
18 Reese Whitfield	Silver tin of chocolates; Bart's "supplier that doesn't exist" remark	G18 and E11
19 Finley Dale	Monday 9 am meeting; spare desk keys	E8 (calendar) and E11

❄ Guest cards you must deal

Four guest cards carry facts the teams need. Dealing in order from G1 always includes them once you have 4 card-holding guests. If any of them is not dealt (8–10 players, or 11–13 players), **you read it aloud** at the start of the round shown. The exact lines are printed with Scripts 1–3.

CARD	GUEST	READ ALOUD IF NOT DEALT
★ G1	Morgan Ashby, Front Desk & Coat Check	Start of Round 1
★ G2	Quinn Oakley, Customer Care	Start of Round 2
★ G3	Tatum Reyes, Accounts Payable	Start of Round 2
★ G4	Blake Okafor, Warehouse & Shipping	Start of Round 3

LAST-MINUTE NO-SHOW BY A CORE SUSPECT?

Hand the booklet to a guest who arrives early (they read pages 1–2 in five minutes) or read that suspect's Round sections aloud yourself as "a statement left with the Detective."

How Team Play Works

11–40 PLAYERS

1. **Make teams at arrival.** Seat people by table, 4–8 per team (3–6 teams). Mix departments; it is a great icebreaker.
2. **Deal guest cards in order** (G1, G2, G3...) to everyone who is not a suspect, one each, up to 20. From 31 players, extra guests join teams without a card. Max 8 per team.
3. **Suspects join teams too.** Each suspect sits with a team, shares what their booklet tells them to share, and helps that team, but **may never vote for themselves**.
4. **Every guest card has three jobs:** share “Something you noticed” with your team, ask a named suspect your question (and write down the answer), and complete a mingle mission.
5. **One Team Case File per table.** The team captain fills in motives, opportunities, the timeline and the clue log.
6. **Evidence goes on one table.** Teams send one runner at a time. For 25+ players, read each new card aloud too.
7. **At the end, each team hands in one ballot:** who, how, why, and two key evidence numbers.

8–10 PLAYERS

No guest cards and no teams: every suspect plays detective, too. Each player fills in an individual ballot (they may not name themselves), and you read the four must-deal lines aloud.

WHY THIS WORKS FOR BIG OFFICES

Nobody is a bystander. Quiet colleagues get a clue, a question and a mission; chatty ones get a suspect role; managers can be the helpers.

Full Party Timeline

ABOUT 2 HRS 15 MIN

CLOCK	MIN	WHAT HAPPENS	YOU
0:00	15	Arrival, name tags, guest cards, teams sit down, snacks	Greet, point to tables
0:15	10	Welcome and the story	Read Script 1
0:25	25	Round 1: E1–E4 on the evidence table	Walk the room, keep time
0:50	5	Round 2 begins	Read Script 2 , add E5–E8
0:55	25	Round 2: food refills welcome	Nudge quiet teams
1:20	5	Round 3 begins	Read Script 3 , add E9–E12
1:25	25	Round 3: final questions, case files	Two-minute warning
1:50	10	Accusations and ballots	Read Script 4 , collect ballots
2:00	10	The reveal	Open 99, read Script 5
2:10	5	Scores and awards	Hand out certificates

Total: 135 minutes. Allow up to 150 by letting rounds run 5 minutes longer when the room is buzzing. Short on time? Trim arrival, never the reveal.

PACING TIP

Rounds end when energy dips, not when the clock says so. If most teams have filled the clue log, move on early.

Lunch-Hour Express

60–75 MINUTES

CLOCK	MIN	WHAT HAPPENS	YOU
0:00	8	Seats, name tags, guest cards; Script 1	Read Script 1 (short version: skip the last two sentences)
0:08	14	Round 1: E1–E4	Keep time
0:22	2	Round 2 begins	Read Script 2, add E5–E8
0:24	14	Round 2	Nudge quiet teams
0:38	2	Round 3 begins	Read Script 3, add E9–E12
0:40	12	Round 3	Two-minute warning
0:52	6	Ballots	Read Script 4
0:58	8	Reveal	Read Script 5
1:06	4	Scores and one award	Best Detective Team

Total: 70 minutes (about 65 if you skip the award).

❄ What changes in Express mode

- Email suspects their booklets two days ahead and ask them to read pages 1–2 before the party.
- Set up tables, case files and evidence before people arrive.
- Suspects read each round's REVEAL lines and skip the mingle mission if time is short.
- Guest cards still matter: ask teams to read every card aloud in Round 1.
- Hand out the Best Detective Team award only, or skip awards entirely.

Evidence Release Plan

WHAT GOES OUT WHEN

ROUND	CARDS ON THE TABLE	CARD TITLES
Round 1 🎁	E1, E2, E3, E4	The Gift Tag · Party Run-of-Show · The Unopened Green Box · Caterer's Dessert Menu
Round 2 🎁 🎁	E5, E6, E7, E8	Toast Photo, 3:42 pm · Bakery Receipt · The Fudge Tin · Shared Calendar Printout
Round 3 🎁 🎁🎁	E9, E10, E11, E12	Company Card Register · Finance Office Phone Log · Bart's Sticky Note · Northstar Invoice

Cards stay on the table for the rest of the game. Teams may read, photograph or copy them, but not carry them away.

❄️ Your job during each round

- Walk between tables and check every team has read the newest cards.
- Answer factual questions about the evidence by re-reading the card. Don't interpret it for them.
- Remind suspects to read their next Round only when you call it.
- If a team stalls, offer a neutral prompt: "Which cards mention a time?" · "Who was not where they said?" · "What did your guest cards learn from the suspects?"
- Give a two-minute warning before each Script.

OPTIONAL EXTRAS IN FILE 30

Page 3 is a printable card back for all 12 cards. Page 4 holds six blank clue cards, useful for a house rule, a prize clue or replacing a lost card.

Script 1 • Opening

READ AT THE START

[Tap the microphone. Wait for quiet.]

Good afternoon, everyone, and welcome to the Evergreen & Pine Co. holiday party. My name is Detective Sam Holloway. I happened to be in the building today, and I'm afraid that puts me in charge.

At 4:15 this afternoon, Bart Pringle, our VP of Sales and this year's Secret Santa organizer, opened his Secret Santa gift: a tin of peppermint fudge. Bart ate two squares, laughed at a joke, and about twenty minutes later collapsed. The paramedics could not revive him.

The lab tells me that something harmful was mixed into that fudge, and only that fudge. Every gift waited on the table in the side hallway before the exchange. That means someone at this party had the chance to tamper with it.

Ten of you knew Bart well enough to be suspects. Everyone else is now a detective, working in teams at your tables. Guests, your cards hold one thing you noticed, one question for a suspect and one mission. Use all three.

Suspects, open your booklets and read Round 1 now. Teams, evidence cards 1 to 4 are on the evidence table. Round 1 starts... now!

HOST ANNOUNCEMENT, ROUND 1 (ONLY IF G1 WAS NOT DEALT)

"Morgan Ashby from the coat check left a statement: at 3:35 pm Bart's gift on the hallway table was a green box with a handwritten tag. At 3:52 pm a midnight-blue box with a printed gold tag sat in its place."

IF AN OPTIONAL SUSPECT IS NOT CAST

Check the drop table on page 5 and read the one line listed there, if any.

Script 2 • Round 2

READ AFTER ROUND 1

[Two-minute warning first. Then ring a bell or tap the mic.]

Attention, please! Round 1 is over, and you have all been busy. I've heard about green boxes, dimmed lights and a very popular cocoa bar.

Four new pieces of evidence, cards 5 to 8, are now on the evidence table. One of them is a photograph taken during the welcome toast. Look closely at who is in it and who is not.

Suspects, you may now open Round 2 in your booklets. Some of you will have to admit things you hoped would stay hidden.

Teams, check your timeline: where was everyone between 3:35 and 3:50? Ask the suspects at your table, and ask the suspects at other tables too.

Round 2 starts now. Snacks are still open!

HOST ANNOUNCEMENTS, ROUND 2 (ONLY IF NOT DEALT)

G2: "Quinn Oakley from Customer Care left a statement: around 3:40 pm someone at the gift table was re-taping a box, back turned, wearing a scarf. The hallway lights were dimmed, so the color was impossible to see."

G3: "Tatum Reyes from Accounts Payable left a statement: at 3:40 pm the Finance office light was off, the door was locked, and nobody answered a knock."

Script 3 • Round 3

READ AFTER ROUND 2

[Two-minute warning first.]

May I have your attention for the final round! We now know a lot about where people were. This round is about money, and about who had the most to lose on Monday morning.

The last four pieces of evidence, cards 9 to 12, are on the table. They came from the front-desk binder, a phone log, Bart's planner and the Finance files.

Suspects, open Round 3. This is the round where secrets come out, so be honest about what your booklet tells you to admit.

Teams, this is your last chance to question anyone. Fill in your Team Case File: who had the motive, who had the opportunity, and who lied.

You have twenty-five minutes. Round 3 begins now.

HOST ANNOUNCEMENT, ROUND 3 (ONLY IF G4 WAS NOT DEALT)

"Blake Okafor from the warehouse left a statement: all year, not one box has arrived from Northstar Ribbon Supply. Our ribbon still comes from Hollyhock Trims."

RUNNING LONG?

Express mode: cut Round 3 to 12 minutes and ask suspects to read only the REVEAL lines.

Script 4 • Accusations

READ AFTER ROUND 3

[Hand one ballot to each team captain, or one per player at 8–10 players.]

Time's up, detectives! Please return to your tables. Every team now gets one accusation ballot.

On it, write who you believe tampered with Bart's gift, how they did it, and why. Then write the numbers of the two pieces of evidence that convinced you most: an E number from the evidence table or a G number from a guest card.

Suspects, you may help your team, but you may not name yourself. The person responsible, I promise, is one of the ten suspects.

You have five minutes. When you're done, bring your ballot to me. No changes after it leaves your hands!

❄ Scoring (also printed on every ballot)

ON THE BALLOT	POINTS
Who: the right suspect	5
How: what they did and when	2
Why: the motive	3
Evidence: each correct key number (max 2)	1 each
Maximum	12

Ties go to the team that handed its ballot in first. Score ballots while you read Script 5; the answers and the list of key evidence numbers are in 99.

Large-Room Tips

20-40 PLAYERS

❄ Sound

- Use a microphone or a portable speaker for every Script. Ten seconds of a bell or a chime gets attention faster than shouting.
- Stand where every table can see you, and repeat key times slowly: "three thirty-five to three fifty."

❄ Two or three helpers

HELPER	JOB
Door helper	Hands out name tags and guest cards in order (G1 first), seats people at team tables
Evidence helper	Guards the evidence table, adds the new cards each round, reads cards aloud for big groups
Time helper (optional)	Gives two-minute warnings, collects ballots, helps score

❄ Hand-out order

1. Suspect booklets go out a week ahead (in envelopes or by email).
2. At the door: name tag, then guest card, then table number.
3. At the tables: Team Case File and pens already waiting.
4. Evidence: Round 1 cards out before Script 1; Round 2 and 3 envelopes stay with you.
5. Ballots: only during Script 4.

TWO EVIDENCE TABLES?

For 30+ players you may print 30 pages 1-2 twice and run two evidence tables at opposite ends of the room (add 2 pages and 12 cards to your print list).

Remote Colleagues & Snacks

❄ Remote colleagues: an honest note

This game is designed for one room: guest cards, evidence and conversations happen face to face. If a few colleagues must join by video, it can still work as **one remote detective team**:

- Email that team the 32 Team Case File PDF and the 04 Cast List.
- Ask one in-room helper to hold the laptop near the evidence table and read each new card aloud.
- Remote players may “ask” suspects through the helper, and submit their ballot by chat.

We don't recommend casting remote players as suspects: much of the fun is in the room.

❄ Festive snacks, no alcohol needed

- **Hot cocoa bar** with marshmallows, whipped cream and peppermint sticks: it is literally in the story.
- **Peppermint fudge squares**, labeled “Safe batch, approved by Detective Holloway.”
- **Gingerbread squares and sugar cookies** on the dessert table, just like Calder's Kitchen.
- **Clementines and cinnamon popcorn** for something lighter.
- **Sparkling cranberry spritzer** (cranberry juice + soda water + rosemary sprig).

ALLERGIES

Label snacks clearly and keep a nut-free plate. Real food should never be a mystery.

Troubleshooting

QUICK ANSWERS

A team is stuck.

Use the neutral prompts on page 9, or ask a suspect at their table to re-read Round 1 aloud.

A suspect revealed something too early.

Laugh it off; the clue trail is in the evidence and guest cards, so nothing breaks.

A guest card was lost.

Copy its text onto a blank card from file 30, page 4, or read the line aloud.

Someone wants to change their vote.

Allow changes until the ballot reaches you; after that it's final.

The room is too loud.

Ask helpers to walk each Script's key line around the tables.

We are running out of time.

Merge Rounds 2 and 3: put out E5-E12 together and give 20 minutes.

A suspect asks you a question about the answer.

"I'm only the Detective. Follow the evidence!" You don't need to know the answer to run the game.

WHEN BALLOTS ARE IN

Open **99 SOLUTION-Host-Only**, read Script 5 slowly, score the ballots, then hand out the awards from file 34. Thank everyone, and enjoy the cocoa.